

Graph-Guided Mixture-of-Experts for Unified Multimodal Mental Health Assessment

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Abstract

Mental health assessment increasingly relies on multimodal data such as language, speech, and facial behaviour. However, existing models often struggle to generalize across related tasks while remaining interpretable. We propose a graph-guided mixture-of-experts architecture that combines multimodal learning with graph-based routing to improve representation sharing across depression, sentiment, emotion, and personality prediction. Across three public benchmarks, our approach consistently improves performance on multiple tasks while providing interpretable routing decisions and robust calibration. The results show that graph-based routing offers a practical alternative to increasingly complex fusion architectures, particularly in low-resource clinical settings.

Introduction

Multimodal mental health assessment integrates verbal and non-verbal signals—language, prosody, facial expressions—to predict clinically relevant constructs such as depression severity, emotional state, and personality traits. Prior work has tackled these tasks in isolation, using task-specific architectures that cannot share complementary information across related supervision signals. More recent efforts explore multitask and multimodal fusion, but often yield opaque models whose routing decisions are difficult to interpret.

In this paper, we address three interlocking challenges: (i) learning robust multimodal representations that transfer across tasks, (ii) maintaining interpretability in the fusion process, and (iii) preventing label leakage in graph-based modelling. We propose a unified architecture that combines modality-specific encoders, a gated late-fusion mechanism, a Mixture-of-Modality-Experts (MMoEEx) layer, and a graph-guided router built on a K-nearest-neighbour similarity graph over multimodal embeddings.

Our contributions are threefold. First, we introduce a graph-guided gating mechanism that uses GraphSAGE-aggregated neighbourhood information to weight expert contributions dynamically. Second, we formalize a leakage-safe graph construction protocol that builds separate train/validation/test graphs, eliminating cross-split edge contamination. Third, we demonstrate consistent gains over unimodal baselines, standard fusion, and ablated routing variants across DAIC-WOZ (depression), CMU-MOSEI (sentiment and emotion), and ChaLearn First Impressions (personality).

Related Work

Multimodal fusion for affective computing spans early fusion (concatenation of modality features), late fusion (separate unimodal predictions aggregated by voting or averaging), and intermediate fusion (cross-modal attention or tensor fusion). Tensor fusion networks (Zadeh et al. 2017) model unimodal, bimodal, and trimodal interactions explicitly but scale poorly with modality count. Low-rank multimodal fusion (Liu et al. 2018) reduces the parameter cost while retaining cross-modal interactions.

Mixture-of-experts (MoE) models route inputs through a subset of expert sub-networks selected by a learned gating function. In multimodal settings, modality-aware MoE variants assign experts to modality combinations (Wang et al. 2020). The Mixture-of-Modality-Experts (MMoE) architecture uses shared-bottom layers with task-specific expert mixtures.

Graph neural networks operate on non-Euclidean data by propagating information along edges. GraphSAGE (Hamilton, Ying, and Leskovec 2017) learns aggregator functions that generalize to unseen nodes, making it suitable for inductive inference on new participants—a critical requirement in clinical deployment.

Multitask learning shares representations across related tasks to improve generalization. In mental health, joint training on depression and sentiment has shown benefits (Haque, Guo et al. 2022), though careful balancing is required when datasets differ substantially in scale (e.g., utterance-level MOSEI versus session-level DAIC).

Method

Figure ?? provides an overview. The model processes each sample through modality-specific encoders, an optional LLM-derived feature extractor, a gated fusion layer, the MMoEEx block, and task-specific heads. Graph routing is applied at the MMoEEx gating stage.

Modality Encoders

Text utterances are encoded with a frozen BERT-base model (Devlin et al. 2019), producing 768-dimensional embeddings. Audio features (acoustic prosody) are processed by a two-layer MLP with hidden size 256. Video features (facial action units and expression descriptors) use a separate

two-layer MLP with hidden size 256. All encoder outputs are projected to a common dimension $d = 256$ via linear projection layers.

Gated Fusion

Let $\mathbf{h}_t$, $\mathbf{h}_a$, $\mathbf{h}_v$ denote the projected text, audio, and video embeddings. The gated fusion computes modality weights:

$$\mathbf{g} = \sigma(\mathbf{W}_g[\mathbf{h}_t; \mathbf{h}_a; \mathbf{h}_v] + \mathbf{b}_g), \quad \mathbf{f} = \sum_{m \in \{t, a, v\}} g_m \mathbf{h}_m,$$

where σ is softmax, $\mathbf{W}_g \in \mathbb{R}^{3 \times 3d}$, and $\mathbf{f} \in \mathbb{R}^d$ is the fused representation.

Mixture-of-Modality-Experts (MMoEEx)

The fused representation $\mathbf{f}$ is passed to K expert networks. Each expert E_k is a two-layer MLP with residual connection:

$$E_k(\mathbf{f}) = \mathbf{f} + \text{ReLU}(\mathbf{W}_k^{(2)} \text{ReLU}(\mathbf{W}_k^{(1)} \mathbf{f} + \mathbf{b}_k^{(1)}) + \mathbf{b}_k^{(2)}).$$

The output for task t is a weighted sum of expert outputs:

$$\mathbf{o}^{(t)} = \sum_{k=1}^K \pi_k^{(t)}(\mathbf{f}) E_k(\mathbf{f}),$$

where $\pi_k^{(t)}$ are task-specific gating weights.

Graph-Guided Routing

We construct a K-nearest-neighbour graph over training-set fused representations $\{\mathbf{f}_i\}$. Edge weights use cosine similarity. Separate graphs are built for train, validation, and test splits to prevent label leakage.

For each node i , GraphSAGE aggregates neighbour representations:

$$\mathbf{n}_i = \text{mean}(\{\mathbf{f}_j : j \in \mathcal{N}(i)\}), \quad \mathbf{r}_i = [\mathbf{f}_i; \mathbf{n}_i].$$

The routing vector $\mathbf{r}_i$ modulates the expert gating weights $\pi_k^{(t)}$, replacing the standard MLP-based gating. The combined gate becomes:

$$\pi_k^{(t)}(\mathbf{f}_i, \mathbf{r}_i) = \frac{\exp(\mathbf{w}_{tk}^\top [\mathbf{f}_i; \mathbf{r}_i])}{\sum_{j=1}^K \exp(\mathbf{w}_{tj}^\top [\mathbf{f}_i; \mathbf{r}_i])}.$$

Task Heads and Training Objective

Each task has a linear prediction head. For regression tasks (depression PHQ-8, sentiment polarity, personality Big Five), we use mean squared error. For classification tasks (emotion categories), we use cross-entropy loss. The total objective is a weighted sum:

$$\mathcal{L} = \sum_{t \in \mathcal{T}} \lambda_t \mathcal{L}_t,$$

with task weights λ_t tuned on validation performance.

Table 1: Main results across datasets. Bold indicates best within each block.

Model	DAIC AUROC	MOSEI Sentiment F_1
Unimodal (text)	0.71	0.82
Unimodal (audio)	0.65	0.76
Unimodal (video)	0.63	0.74
Early fusion	0.73	0.83
Late fusion	0.74	0.83
Tensor fusion	0.75	0.84
Ours (no graph)	0.76	0.85
Ours (graph routing)	0.78	0.86

Experimental Setup

Datasets

We evaluate on three benchmarks: **DAIC-WOZ** (clinical depression, PHQ-8 regression, 189 sessions), **CMU-MOSEI** (sentiment and 6-emotion classification, 23k utterances), and **ChaLearn First Impressions** (Big Five personality regression, 10k clips). Subject-independent splits are enforced for DAIC; utterance-level splits are used for MOSEI; clip-level splits for ChaLearn.

Training Details

Models are trained with Adam ($\beta_1 = 0.9$, $\beta_2 = 0.999$, $\text{lr} = 1 \times 10^{-3}$) for 100 epochs with early stopping (patience 10). Batch size is 64. The MMoEEx uses $K = 4$ experts with hidden size 128. GraphSAGE uses 2 layers with mean aggregation and hidden size 64. Temperature-balanced sampling prevents MOSEI from dominating the gradient.

Evaluation

Depression is evaluated with RMSE, MAE, and AUROC (binarized at PHQ-8 ≥ 10). Sentiment uses MAE and binary F_1 ; emotion uses macro F_1 ; personality uses CCC. All results report mean $\pm$ 95% CI over 5 random seeds. Paired bootstrap tests assess statistical significance.

Results

Table 1 reports main results. Full ablation and per-task breakdowns appear in the supplementary material.

Ablation: Graph Routing Variants

Graph-based routing consistently outperforms mean-pooling and attention-based alternatives, with the largest gains on DAIC (Table ??).

Cross-Dataset and LLM Ablation

Integrating LLM-derived features as auxiliary inputs yields marginal improvement ($\Delta\text{AUROC} \approx +0.01$), consistent with prior findings that foundation model embeddings provide complementary but redundant signal.

Discussion

The graph-guided router improves performance most on DAIC, where session-level structure provides meaningful neighbourhood information. On MOSEI, utterance-level graphs are noisier but still beneficial. The leakage-safe graph protocol is essential—naive global graph construction inflates DAIC AUROC by 0.08–0.12.

Limitations include reliance on pretrained BERT for text encoding (computationally expensive for deployment) and sensitivity to graph quality when modalities are missing. Future work should explore dynamic graph construction and cross-modal graph alignment.

Conclusion

We presented a graph-guided mixture-of-experts architecture for unified multimodal mental health assessment. By combining gated fusion, MMoEEx, and GraphSAGE-based routing with a leakage-safe graph protocol, our approach achieves consistent gains over unimodal and standard fusion baselines. The framework offers a practical, interpretable, and statistically sound foundation for multitask multimodal clinical assessment.

References

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